Chinese elements, unaware of Havildar Malkiat's position above and to the west of them, were caught completely unawares by the deadly LMG fire. By now the Nam Ka Chu Valley was completely lit up and the surrounding hills echoed with the sound of gunfire. The Rajputs were strung out in single file and the leading elements were almost at Temporary Bridge while Rikh's party at the rear was approaching Bridge 4.

Kaul then seemed to arrive at a decision. He called Rikh over and announced that 2 Rajput was to advance no further as the situation had changed. He said he was immediately leaving with his staff for Delhi to apprise the prime minister of the serious intent of the Chinese. He turned to Niranjan Prasad and declared that the orders to drive the Chinese across the Thagla were to be held in abeyance until he returned. In the meantime, the brigade was to continue to hold its position on the south bank of the Nam Ka Chu at all costs. The position across the river at Tsangle was also to be held unless it was attacked in strength by the Chinese, in which case he was leaving it to the discretion of the GOC. Turning to Rikh, he repeated his orders, telling the CO that he was to advance no further as the situation had changed. He wanted Temporary Bridge, Log Bridge, Bridge 4 and Bridge 3 to be held by a company of 2 Rajput. Rikh protested, saying these positions were all dominated by the Thagla Ridge and would be impossible to hold in the event of a Chinese attack. Kaul replied that these were only temporary defensive positions and the Chinese would not attack so long as the Indians stayed on the south bank of the Nam Ka Chu. Having said that, Kaul added that not a single inch of territory was to be given up regardless of the cost. He then turned to Dalvi and, nodding in the direction of the hapless Punjab patrol fighting it out at Tseng Jong, declared: 'It's now your battle.' Having said that, Kaul, along with the GOC and his staff officers, left the scene, walking off briskly towards Bridge 3 from where he would exit the Nam Ka Chu Theatre by helicopter from Tsangdhar.

With the abrupt departure of the corps commander, Dalvi, back in command of his brigade, could now focus on the battle raging across the river.

Their first attack having been halted, the Chinese tried to neutralize the LMG section with mortar and MMG (medium machine gun) fire. However, the position had been very well sited in defilade (using natural or artificial obstacles to provide cover) and Chinese fire, though intense and concentrated, could not get at Malkiat Singh's position. While the Chinese